

BME80G: Oral Debate Student Instructions

Overview

The oral debate is the final component of the course project. You have already selected a topic and side (Part I) and completed your written debate preparation (Part II). The debate gives you the opportunity to present your position in real time and demonstrate the depth of preparation you have built over the quarter. This is a moderator-led forum, not a direct cross-examination between teams. The moderator poses questions to both sides, and the assigned student from each side responds in turn, presenting their perspective on the same question. Students do not question each other directly.

Before You Arrive: What to Prepare

Every student must bring two prepared documents to the debate. You will not know your assigned role until you arrive.

1. A brief opening statement (2 minutes when read aloud, approximately 250–300 words)

Your opening statement introduces your team's position to the moderator and audience. It should name the issue, state your central claim, and briefly preview your team's strongest arguments. Write it out in full so you can deliver it confidently.

2. A brief closing statement (2 minutes when read aloud, approximately 250–300 words)

Your closing statement is the last thing the audience hears from your side. It should summarize the strongest points your team made, acknowledge the most significant challenge the other side raised, and leave the audience with a clear sense of why your position prevails. Do not introduce new arguments in the closing.

Role Assignment on the day of your assigned debate

When you arrive, you will be randomly assigned a number. Students on Side A receive A1, A2, A3, or A4. Students on Side B receive B1, B2, B3, or B4. With three students per side, assignments run A1–A3 and B1–B3. Paired students share the same set of moderator questions.

Every student has three total assignments: either an opening or closing statement plus two moderator questions, or three moderator questions.

For example, with 4 students per side:

#	Assignments	What you do	Fallback rule
A1 B1	Opening statement + 2 moderator questions	Deliver the opening statement for your side. Then respond to 2 questions posed by the moderator.	<i>If A1 has no opening statement, A2 delivers it and still answers their own 3 questions. Same for B1 and B2.</i>
A2 B2	3 moderator questions	Respond to 3 questions posed by the moderator, presenting your side's position on each.	<i>May be asked to deliver the opening statement if A1 or B1 is unprepared.</i>
A3 B3	3 moderator questions	Respond to 3 questions posed by the moderator, presenting your side's position on each.	<i>May be asked to deliver the closing statement if A4 or B4 is unprepared.</i>
A4 B4	2 moderator questions + closing statement	Respond to 2 questions posed by the moderator, then deliver the closing statement for your side.	<i>If A4 has no closing statement, A3 delivers it instead. Same for B4 and B3.</i>

With 3 students per side:

#	Assignments	What you do	Fallback rule
A1 B1	Opening statement + 2 moderator questions	Deliver the opening statement for your side, then respond to 2 moderator questions.	<i>If A1 has no opening statement, A2 delivers it instead. Same for B1 and B2.</i>
A2 B2	3 moderator questions	Respond to 3 questions posed by the moderator, presenting your side's position on each.	<i>May be asked to deliver the opening or closing statement if A1, B1, A3, or B3 is unprepared.</i>
A3 B3	2 moderator questions + closing statement	Respond to 2 moderator questions, then deliver the closing statement for your side.	<i>If A3 has no closing statement, A2 delivers it instead. Same for B3 and B2.</i>

Debate Format and Order of Events

The debate moves through three phases. The moderator (typically, your TA) controls the pace and will signal when time is up for each response.

1: Opening Statements

A1 delivers the opening statement for Side A, followed immediately by B1 for Side B. Each is 2 minutes. If either student is unprepared, the student with the next higher number delivers it instead.

2: Moderated Q&A Rounds

The moderator poses one question at a time. The assigned Side A student responds first, followed by the assigned Side B student. The debate moves through students in numerical order: A1 and B1 in Round 1, A2 and B2 in Round 2, and so on. Each question will fall into one of the four types described above.

3: Closing Statements

A4 (or A3 in a 3-student debate) delivers the closing for Side A, followed by B4 (or B3) for Side B. Each is 2 minutes. If the assigned student is unprepared, the next lower number delivers it instead.

Timing

The moderator will keep time and signal when each response should wrap up. A focused, well-structured response is more effective than a longer rambling one.

Phase	Activity	Time
Opening statements	A1 opening statement (2 min) + B1 opening statement (2 min)	4 min
Round 1 (A1 + B1)	Moderator asks question(s) 1 A1 responds / B1 responds	~3.5 min
	Moderator asks question(s) 2 (same format)	~3.5 min
Round 2 (A2 + B2)	Moderator asks question(s) 3 A2 responds / B2 responds	~3.5 min
	Moderator asks question(s) 4 (same format)	~3.5 min
	Moderator asks question(s) 5 (same format)	~3.5 min
Round 3 (A3 + B3)	Moderator asks question(s) 6 A3 responds / B3 responds	~3.5 min
	Moderator asks question(s) 7 (same format)	~3.5 min
	Moderator asks question(s) 8 (same format)	~3.5 min

Round 4 (A4 + B4)	Moderator asks question(s) 9 A4 responds / B4 responds	~3.5 min
	Moderator asks question(s) 10 (same format)	~3.5 min
Closing statements	A4 closing statement (2 min) + B4 closing statement (2 min)	4 min
Total		~45 min

With 3 students per side — target: 30 minutes

Each exchange: ~30 sec moderator question + ~75 sec Side A response + ~75 sec Side B response = ~3 min per question

Phase	Activity	Time
Opening statements	A1 opening statement (2 min) + B1 opening statement (2 min)	4 min
Round 1 (A1 + B1)	Moderator asks question(s) 1 A1 responds / B1 responds	~3.5 min
	Moderator asks question(s) 2 (same format)	~3.5 min
Round 2 (A2 + B2)	Moderator asks question(s) 3 A2 responds / B2 responds	~3.5 min
	Moderator asks question(s) 4 (same format)	~3.5 min
	Moderator asks question(s) 5 (same format)	~3.5 min
Round 3 (A3 + B3)	Moderator asks question(s) 6 A3 responds / B3 responds	~3.5 min
	Moderator asks question(s) 7 (same format)	~3.5 min
Closing statements	A3 closing statement (2 min) + B3 closing statement (2 min)	4 min
Total		~35 min

Tips for Debate Day

Know your ethical frameworks cold. Normative ethics and four principles questions are guaranteed. Review all six frameworks and all four principles before the debate

Opening and closing students set the tone. A1 and B1 frame the entire debate for the audience. A4 and B4 have the final word.

What Types of Questions to Expect

Your team is guaranteed to receive at least one question from each of the three categories below.

Question type	
Normative ethics	How your team's position connects to a specific ethical framework from class.
Four principles of bioethics	How your argument relates to one or more of the four principles: autonomy, beneficence, non-maleficence, or justice.
Module content	Relevant material can be used from the class